

NUCLEAR BOMBERS AND INTERCEPTORS

For twenty years after the attacks on Hiroshima (see pp.378–79) and Nagasaki in 1945, the long-range strategic bomber – which had to be fast and capable of carrying a heavy payload – remained a vital element in every nuclear power's arsenal. A new type of fighter aircraft was produced to counter this threat – the exceptionally fast “interceptor”, whose role was to shoot down bombers before they could do any significant damage. By the mid-1960s, however, the development of Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles (ICBMs), such as the submarine-launched Polaris missile, rendered the strategic bomber obsolete; the role of the interceptor was reduced accordingly.



▲ BOEING B-47 STRATOJET

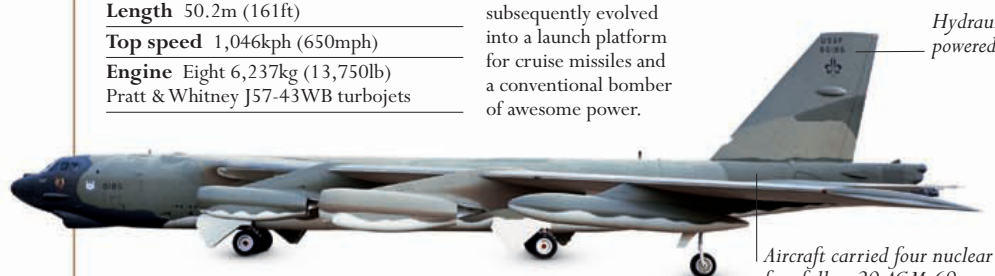
Date 1950 **Origin** US
Wingspan 35.4m (116¼ft)
Length 32.6m (106¾ft)
Top speed 980kph (606mph)
Engine Six 3,266kg (7,185lb) General Electric J47-GE-25 turbojets

One of the first jet bombers to serve with the US Strategic Air Command, the B47 featured a swept-back wing and a substantial internal bomb load.

▼ BOEING B-52 STRATOFORTRESS

Date 1955 **Origin** US
Wingspan 56.4m (185ft)
Length 50.2m (161ft)
Top speed 1,046kph (650mph)
Engine Eight 6,237kg (13,750lb) Pratt & Whitney J57-43WB turbojets

The long-serving B-52 was designed to drop nuclear bombs on the Soviet Union (which it never did), but subsequently evolved into a launch platform for cruise missiles and a conventional bomber of awesome power.



▼ AVRO 698 VULCAN B2

Date 1956 **Origin** UK
Wingspan 33.9m (111¼ft)
Length 30.5m (100ft)
Top speed 1,029kph (640mph)
Engine Four 9,992kg (22,000lb) Bristol Siddeley Olympus turbojets

During the late 1950s, the British nuclear deterrent was spearheaded by Vulcan B2. It had a distinctive delta wing that helped ensure good load-carrying capabilities and a high subsonic speed.

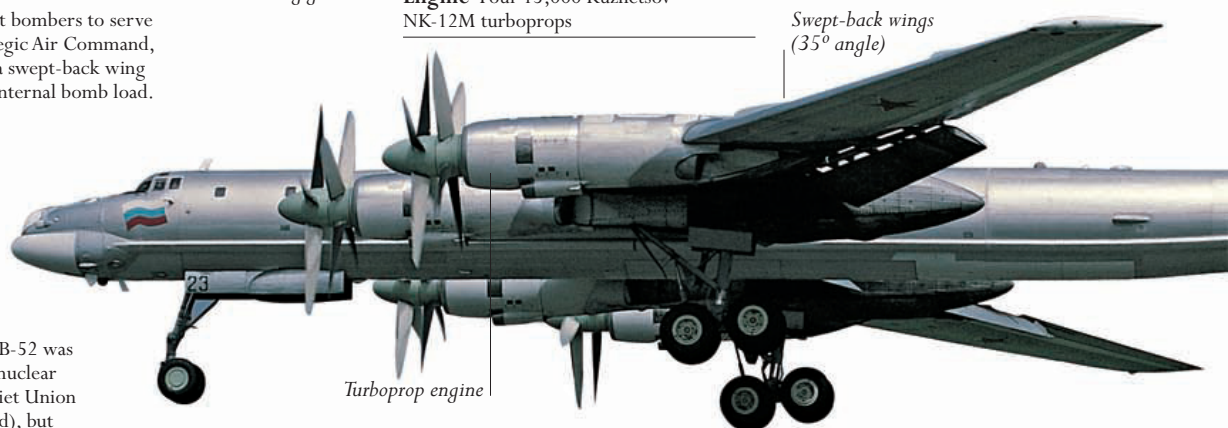
Aircraft carried four nuclear free-fall or 20 AGM-69 SRAM missiles, or up to 27,200kg (60,000lb) of conventional bombs



▼ TUPOLEV TU-95 “BEAR”

Date 1955 **Origin** Soviet Union
Wingspan 50.1m (164½ft)
Length 46.2m (151½ft)
Top speed 905kph (562mph)
Engine Four 15,000 Kuznetsov NK-12M turboprops

Although equipped with turboprop engines, the Tu-95 demonstrated high performance characteristics that included an exceptional range (with bomb load) of 15,000km (9,300 miles) without refuelling.



Hydraulically powered rudder



Twin tail fins

Underwing fuel tank